

Chapter 124-1

Winter in Haizhou City was shorter than other seasons.

The biting winds of late autumn had been blowing for a long time, yet true winter still hadn't arrived. The continuous autumn rains had fallen several times, each followed by drops in temperature that would then rise again.

Just like riding a roller coaster.

Even though, according to the solar terms, it was already early winter.

Last night's wind wasn't unfounded¹—after a night of wind, rain indeed fell by evening. The red clouds spreading across the distant horizon were instantly covered by dark clouds. The change in the sky was just a matter of an instant.

The wind kept blowing against the windows, making the bare trees outside sway back and forth.

Liang Shi didn't bother with the shattered glass at her feet. She kept enlarging the picture, again and again.

—Rumble.

The sudden flash of light tore a huge gash in the dim sky, as if trying to swallow the entire mortal world into its belly. Accompanying it was deafening thunder.

The wind blew the window open, making Liang Shi's back turn ice cold.

To be precise, her entire body was ice cold.

In the photo, Xu Qingzhu's eyes were covered with black cloth, her hands bound behind her back with thick hemp rope, and her mouth was taped with black tape. She was wearing the same clothes she had worn when leaving in the morning, only now they were stained with dirt.

Xu Qingzhu's feet were bound together with black electrical cord, looking as if they had been tied with whatever was at hand.

She was curled up in a corner, her head drooping limply, as if unconscious.

The wicked wind and cold rain made her mood even worse. In a moment of panic and chaos, she made a video call to Xu Qingzhu.

But the other side hung up immediately.

A three-second voice message came from there, the voice processed through a voice changer: "Do you want to save her?"

Liang Shi was about to call the police when another voice message came: "Then come to the address I give you. If you call the police, I'll kill her right now."

What followed was a short video.

In the video, Xu Qingzhu still showed no reaction, but a sharp knife was pressed against her cheek. The silver blade contrasted with her skin tone, making one's heart pound with fear, dreading the sight of blood.

The other party sent an address—in the outskirts of Haizhou City.

That entire area hadn't been demolished yet. The Haizhou city government planned to develop it heavily in a few years, supposedly to build a new amusement park and shopping mall.

But right now, it was a desolate wasteland.

Liang Shi knew about this place because Xu Qingzhu had told her. Xu Qingzhu had said that if she wanted to invest in property, she could wait for houses in that area—there should be great potential for appreciation.

Voice messages kept coming.

"She hasn't woken up yet. Do you think if I slowly torture her here, will it trigger her PTSD?"

"She seems to be afraid of having her eyes covered, did you know?"

"If you want her to live, then do as I say obediently."

"Come to the address I sent within one hour, otherwise... what you'll see when you arrive will definitely be a corpse."

"Or maybe a naked body. Hehe."

Five consecutive voice messages, the tone becoming increasingly outrageous. Listening to them made Liang Shi clench her fists.

Her originally groggy mind was now completely clear, yet it was constantly being clouded by anger. She wished she could reach through the internet and beat this person to death.

But after the tremendous anger subsided, Liang Shi pressed on her phone screen and tried to negotiate with the other party as calmly as possible: "What do you want? Money?"

"Or do you want revenge on me? Then come at me directly. I can exchange myself for her."

"If you want revenge on me, then you should kidnap me, torture me, kill me—that would be more satisfying. What's the point of kidnapping a stranger?"

"How much money do you want?"

The intervals between Liang Shi's voice messages weren't short. She tried her best to maintain calm thoughts to think through this matter.

She also tried not to let the other party discover how important Xu Qingzhu was to her.

Although her "trying her best" was also a barely controllable effort.

Her fingernails pressing on the phone screen had turned white. Her face, which had been slightly flushed from grogginess earlier, was now pale as paper—a shocking sight.

Yet Liang Shi didn't notice.

She kept guessing who the kidnapper was, and what purpose they had in kidnapping Xu Qingzhu.

If the other party wanted to kill the hostage, they could have just killed Xu Qingzhu directly. But now they were contacting her through Xu Qingzhu's WeChat, which meant they had other intentions?

They hadn't mentioned money at all, only specifically asked her to come—for what purpose?

Revenge against her?

The original owner had offended so many people, so this possibility couldn't be ruled out.

But how did the other party know that Xu Qingzhu had PTSD?

In just a few short minutes, a storm raged through Liang Shi's mind.

She searched through possible people in her head, and ultimately could only think of one—Chen Liuying.

Footnotes:

¹ **Not unfounded (空穴來風):** This is a Chinese idiom that literally means "wind coming from an empty cave." It refers to rumors or occurrences that have some basis in reality—where there's smoke, there's fire. The original text had a typo (空xue來風) which has been corrected in translation.